

The Five Gospels

"Gospel" refers to the core message of salvation/eternal life as each author presents it. They're presented in the likely (and very important) chronological order of composition.

PAUL ~50-65 CE · MAINLY ROMANS AND GALATIANS	MARK ~65-70 CE · EARLIEST NARRATIVE GOSPEL	MATTHEW ~80-90 CE · EXPANDS MARK	LUKE/ACTS ~80-90 CE · EXPANDS MARK	JOHN ~90-100 CE · INDEPENDENT
CHRISTOLOGY ➤ Jesus is a divine pre-existent being "in the form of God" (Phil 2:5-7) ➤ Declared the Son of God by his resurrection (Rom 1:1-6) SALVATION/ETERNAL LIFE ➤ Have faith in the atoning death and resurrection of Christ (Rom 5) ➤ Baptism — not for forgiveness, but to be united with Christ in his death and resurrection (Rom 6:1-11) ➤ Stop sinning — the Holy Spirit enables those united with Christ to overcome sin's power (Rom 6 & 8) UNIQUE TO PAUL (SEE DETAILS BELOW) ➤ The Law is obsolete ➤ Sin is a cosmic power that controls everyone ➤ Atonement instead of forgiveness ➤ Righteousness through faith instead of obedience ➤ Election and predestination instead of free will	CHRISTOLOGY ➤ Declared the Son of God at his baptism after receiving the Holy Spirit. (1:9-11) ➤ No pre-existence ➤ No miraculous conception SALVATION/ETERNAL LIFE ➤ Repent and be baptized for the forgiveness of your sins (1:4-5, and echoed in Matt 3:1-12 & Luke 3:1-3) ➤ Obey God's commandments in order to inherit eternal life (10:17-21, and echoed in Matt 19:16-21 & Luke 18:18-22) ➤ Many ordinary people are righteous, and Jesus explicitly said he was not calling them (2:13-17, and echoed in Matt 9:9-13 & Luke 5:27-32) ➤ Faith is important for prayer and healing, but it's not presented as a requirement for eternal life (consistent with Matthew and Luke). UNIQUE TO MARK ➤ No post-resurrection appearances (16:9-20 is not in the earliest mss.)	CHRISTOLOGY ➤ Declared the Son of God at his miraculous conception, which was announced to Joseph (1:18-25) KEY ADDITIONS TO MARK ➤ Post-resurrection appearances (28:16-20) UNIQUE TO MATTHEW ➤ Ministry directed to the Jews only (10:5-7, 15:24) ➤ Emphasis on the continuing importance of the Law (5:17-20) ➤ Righteousness is evident by: – Sincere (not ostentatious) obedience to the Law (5:17-20) – Active care for "the least of these" (25:31-46) ➤ Anachronistic references to the church (16:18, 18:15-17) ➤ Everlasting blood-guilt of the Jews (27:24-25) ➤ Many among the righteous dead were raised before Jesus himself was (27:51-53)	CHRISTOLOGY ➤ Same as Matthew, except the conception was announced to Mary (1:26-35) KEY ADDITIONS/CHANGES ➤ Implies Jesus was sent for Gentiles rather than Jews (Luke 4:16–30) ➤ Omits the "Son of Man came to give his life as a ransom for many" saying found in both Mark and Matthew ➤ Speeches in Acts don't say "Jesus died for your sins" — they say "You killed Jesus, but God raised him. Now repent." (Acts 2:14-40, 3:11-26, 4:5-12, 5:27-32) ➤ Many thousands of believers still zealous for the Law decades after the resurrection (Acts 21:17–20) UNIQUE TO LUKE ➤ Good Samaritan, Prodigal Son, Rich Man and Lazarus ➤ Jesus' ascension to heaven (Luke 24:50-53, Acts 1:1-12)	CHRISTOLOGY ➤ Has existed as God for all eternity (1:1-5), and became the human Son of God to take away the sins of humanity (1:14, 29) SALVATION/ETERNAL LIFE ➤ Believe in Jesus as the Son of God (3:14-18; 20:30-31) ➤ Be "born again" / "born of water and the Spirit" (3:1-8) UNIQUE TO JOHN ➤ Jesus talks explicitly, frequently, and at great length about his own divinity ➤ The seven "I am" statements ➤ Seven miracles as "signs" to inspire belief (most notably, raising Lazarus) ➤ Foot washing at the Last Supper instead of the bread and cup ➤ Jesus is calm, resolute, and fully in control before his arrest and on the cross ("It is finished" vs. Mark & Matthew's "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?")

PAUL'S DISTINCTIVE DOCTRINES
SIN
➤ Sin is not merely disobedience — it's also a cosmic power. It's essentially an unholy spirit that possesses and controls everyone (Rom 6 & 7) ➤ Because of Adam, everyone is born utterly sinful with no hope of escape (Rom 5) ➤ Accordingly, there's no such thing as a righteous person (Rom 3)
THE LAW
➤ Obedience to the Law can't make anyone righteous (Gal 2 & 3, Rom 3 & 4) ➤ The Law was actually a trap for the Israelites (Rom 9:30-33), because its main purpose was to curse, enslave, and condemn them (Gal 3 & 4). ➤ Regardless, Christ's death made it obsolete (Rom 6 & 7)
ATONEMENT VS. FORGIVENESS
➤ God's justice cannot simply forgive sins — he requires death (Rom 6:23). ➤ Note: Atonement entails restitution to eliminate a debt; forgiveness does not. ➤ Jesus' death was the atoning payment for the sins of humanity (Rom 3 & 5) ➤ Baptism "into Christ" and his death/resurrection appropriates that atonement and frees the person from sin's power (Rom 6) ➤ If God could simply forgive sins, then Jesus would have died for nothing
RIGHTEOUSNESS/JUSTIFICATION
➤ Attained through faith only, not obedience to the Law (Gal 2:16, Rom 3:28, 4:5) ➤ Entire doctrine based on two proof texts: Gen 15:6 and Hab 2:4
ELECTION/PREDESTINATION
➤ God chooses the eternal destiny of people based on his own preferences and plans (Rom 8:28-33; all of Rom 9) ➤ To ensure his own glory, he hardens the hearts of certain people (Rom 9:14-18) ➤ Only a remnant of the Israelites will actually be saved because he subsequently hardened most of them and caused them to stumble (Rom 9 & 11)

GOSPEL COMPARISONS — KEY FEATURES					
FEATURE	PAUL	MARK	MATTHEW	LUKE	JOHN
Divine pre-existence	Yes	No	No	No	Yes
Miraculous conception	No	No	Yes	Yes	No
Birth story and genealogy	No	No	Yes	Yes	No
Baptism story	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Implied
Temptation, parables, ethical teachings, exorcisms, transfiguration	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	No
Post-resurrection appearances	Yes	No ¹	Galilee	Jerusalem	Both
Ascension story	No	No ¹	No	Twice ²	No
Holy Spirit given to the disciples	No	No	No	In Acts 2	Yes
Earthly kingdom of God	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	No
God predetermines who will be saved	Yes	No	No	No	Yes
Righteous people exist	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Unclear
Repentance emphasis	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	No
Forgiveness of sins	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes ³
Atonement emphasis	Strong	Brief	Brief	Minimal ⁴	Unclear
Law still valid	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Unclear
1: Mark 16:9–20 (post-resurrection appearances and ascension to heaven) is not in the earliest manuscripts 2: Luke 24:50–53 (occurs at Bethany on the same day as the resurrection); Acts 1:1-12 (occurs forty days later at Mount Olivet/Mount of Olives) 3: Only after the resurrection, and it's mediated through the Spirit-filled disciples (20:19-23) 4: Luke retains the Last Supper dialogue, but omits the "Son of Man came to give his life as a ransom for many" saying found in both Mark and Matthew					

SUMMARY — THE CORE DIFFERENCES		
QUESTION	PAUL	MARK, MATTHEW, AND LUKE
Who is the authoritative Jesus?	The risen heavenly Christ; Paul never met the earthly Jesus, and references to his life are sparse	Jesus of Nazareth; his earthly ministry was the foundation of the gospel message
How is eternal life attained?	Only by faith in Christ's death and resurrection (and it's only for those predestined by God)	Obedience to the commandments, especially those about caring for the weak and helpless
Is the Law still active?	No, it's now obsolete; its main purpose was to convict and condemn humanity until Jesus came	Yes, it's still fully valid and binding; obedience to it is central to attaining eternal life
Do righteous people exist?	No — all humanity is enslaved to the power of sin because of Adam	Yes — Jesus explicitly acknowledged righteous people and said he wasn't calling them
Does God forgive sins?	No — his justice requires atonement through death	Yes — freely, upon repentance and baptism